

SOFIA VALDEZ

Austin, TX • (956) 334-6429 • sofiavaldez77@gmail.com • sofiavaldez77.github.io/portfolio

UX researcher and consumer insights strategist with a PhD in human-AI interaction and a track record of translating research into product, marketing, and brand decisions that stick. Work still lives in production over a year later.

EXPERIENCE

UX Research & Design Intern | Moxee Technologies, Bellevue, WA *Sept 2024 – Mar 2025*

Project 1: Onboarding-to-Checkout Conversion Optimization (Assigned, Independently Led)

- Conducted think-aloud usability interviews with target users and mapped the full acquisition journey from ad to checkout, diagnosing two core drop-off drivers: an intent mismatch between ads and funnel, and an end-to-end experience that incited hesitation at every stage.
- Synthesized findings into a customer needs framework across 11 needs grouped into three themes: trust, process clarity, and information access; benchmarked competitors against each need for market competitive design requirements.
- Went beyond scope to collaborate with marketing on landing page alongside product, addressing intent and trust at every touchpoint — then redesigned the funnel as a single scrollable page with contextual guidance at each step.
- Drove a 2.5x checkout conversion lift in under one month, exceeding the 2x goal. Design carried to all Moxee brands and still in use over a year later.

Project 2: Customer Insights for Product & Marketing Strategy (Self-Initiated, Independently Led)

- Identified that interviews with target users had strategic implications beyond its brief; navigated stakeholder resistance and expanded scope to a full consumer insights program covering switching motivations, pricing sensitivities, feature preferences, and service discovery.
- Recruited 50+ participants in one day via incentive-based system; completed 25 hour-long interviews with Chinese international students.
- Surfaced that the team's planned six-figure engineering investment in family plans was misaligned with actual user needs — participants wanted a pause plan for summers abroad, which Moxee could already offer with no engineering work.
- Delivered cross-functional recommendations spanning product strategy, marketing campaigns, pricing structure, and brand positioning; most were implemented. The Bye Bye Family Plan campaign, referral incentives, pause plan, and current pricing all came out of this project.
- Presentation still shared with every new hire at Panda Mobile over a year later.

Graduate Researcher | The University of Texas at Austin, Austin, TX *Aug 2020 – Aug 2025*

- Conducted a controlled mixed-methods study (n=79) on human-AI collaboration in design, combining quantitative behavioral metrics with qualitative thematic and sentiment analysis. Core finding: outcomes in human-AI collaboration are determined not by AI capability, but by whether users' expected role matches their experienced role — directly applicable to AI product design and onboarding.
- Built an AI-powered interactive design tool from scratch — generating own dataset, training a generative AI model, and developing a real-time latent space interaction suite — then studied how people experienced it across conditions.
- Collaborated with a furniture retailer and a 3D printing manufacturer to translate research into a real-world product enabling customers to design and 3D print custom furniture from recycled plastic.
- Conducted 130+ user interviews and studies across customers, students, and industry partners to inform iterative improvements to AI models, tools, and interface design.
- 2 published conference papers; 1 journal paper under review at Journal of Mechanical Design.

Design Method Teaching Assistant | University of Texas at Austin, Austin, TX *Aug 2021 – May 2022*

- Mentored student teams through company-sponsored design projects, guiding them from customer research through prototyping and functional build.

Data Science Intern | National Renewable Energy Laboratory, Austin, TX *June – Aug 2021*

- Built an ML model to predict power usage effectiveness months in advance; reduced data center energy balance algorithm latency from hours to seconds via real-time data ingestion.

Product Design Intern | Halliburton, Elmendorf, TX *June – Aug 2019*

- Conducted 50+ interviews across field operators, technicians, engineers, and real estate managers to identify workflow inefficiencies; designed and implemented cost-saving solutions with \$200K/year potential at the Elmendorf facility.

EDUCATION

PhD, Mechanical Engineering — Advanced Design & Human-AI Interaction

Aug 2025

The University of Texas at Austin • GPA: 3.80 • NSF Graduate Research Fellow, GEM Fellow, Virginia & Ernest Cockrell Jr. Fellow

BS, Mechanical Engineering

May 2020

The University of Texas at Austin • Minor: McCombs Business Foundations • GPA: 3.96 • Hispanic Scholarship Fund Scholar

SKILLS & TOOLS

Research Methods: Mixed-methods design, usability testing, think-aloud interviews, concept testing, surveys, journey mapping, affinity mapping, thematic analysis, customer needs synthesis, competitive analysis, behavioral data analysis

AI & Product: Human-AI interaction research, Human-computer interaction, AI-powered product experience, generative AI, agentic design, onboarding and growth research, B2C product strategy

Design Tools: Figma, wireframing, prototyping, interaction design, information architecture, user flows

Technical: Python, R, SQL, MATLAB, machine learning, deep learning, data visualization, statistical analysis

ADDITIONAL

Publications: Valdez et al., A Framework for Interactive Structural Design Exploration, IDETC/CIE 2021; Latent Variable Representations for Interactive Structural Design Exploration, IDETC/CIE 2022; Evaluating Human-AI Interaction in GAN-Based Structural Design, IDETC 2025. Journal paper under review: Journal of Mechanical Design.

Languages: Native English and Spanish

Leadership: Graduate Liaison, Society of Hispanic Professional Engineers; Mentor, Freshman Introduction to Research in Engineering